DEGREE 1

Foundations of Political Thought & Social Analysis

Goal: acquire the vocabulary and frameworks needed before analyzing any particular country.

WHAT THIS DEGREE BUILDS

This degree gives you the core language of political and social analysis: power, sovereignty, legitimacy, rights, freedom, institutions, class, authority, markets, and development. The aim is to build conceptual lenses, not simply memorize thinkers.

KEY THINKERS

Machiavelli
power

Hobbes
order

Locke
rights

Rousseau
freedom

COURSE 1

Political Philosophy

1. Machiavelli & Hobbes - power, sovereignty, order
2. Locke & Rousseau - rights, consent, social contract
3. Liberty, democracy, citizenship, majority rule
4. Connect the thinkers and compare their answers

COURSE 2

Modern Social Theory

1. Adam Smith & Marx - capitalism, class, alienation
2. Durkheim - solidarity, institutions, religion
3. Weber - authority, bureaucracy, rationalization
4. Synthesis - structure, culture, class, agency

COURSE 3

Comparative Politics & the Modern State

1. State, nation, sovereignty & legitimacy
2. Democracy and authoritarianism
3. Institutions, parties, bureaucracy & civil society
4. Nationalism, revolution, democratization & state-building

COURSE 4

Political Economy & Development

1. Markets, capitalism and the state
2. Labor, class and competing theories of capitalism
3. Development, inequality and institutions
4. Global political economy and competing explanations

DEGREE 2

Empire, Colonialism & Decolonization

Goal: understand colonialism historically, economically, politically, culturally, and psychologically - including its critics.

WHAT THIS DEGREE BUILDS

This degree specializes the tools from Degree 1. It asks how empires were built and governed, how colonialism shaped economies and institutions, how it affected identity and psychology, and how anti-colonial and postcolonial thinkers explained - and disagreed about - those effects.

KEY THINKERS

Fanon
psychology

Said
representation

Cesaire
critique

Rodney
development

COURSE 1

Histories of Empire & Colonial Rule

1. Empire before modern European colonialism
2. European expansion, conquest and colonial administration
3. Settler, extractive and indirect-rule systems
4. Colonial legacies: borders, institutions and social hierarchy

COURSE 2

Imperialism & Political Economy

1. Capitalism, trade and empire
2. Marxist theories of imperialism and their critics
3. Colonial extraction, labor and development
4. Dependency, underdevelopment and postcolonial economies

COURSE 3

Anti-Colonial Thought & Decolonization

1. Aime Cesaire - colonialism and civilization
2. Frantz Fanon - Black Skin, White Masks
3. Fanon - The Wretched of the Earth
4. National liberation, violence, nation-building and postcolonial elites

COURSE 4

Orientalism & Postcolonial Thought

1. Edward Said - Orientalism: representation and knowledge
2. Culture, discourse and power
3. Spivak / Bhabha as later extensions
4. Criticisms: evidence, agency, material history, competing explanations

DEGREE 3

Applied Comparative Analysis

Goal: move from theory to disciplined analysis of Iran, the Middle East, or another society without assuming one explanation in advance.

WHAT THIS DEGREE BUILDS

This is the application stage. You build a historical timeline, test several theoretical lenses against the evidence, compare competing explanations, and identify what each lens explains well and what it leaves out.

KEY THINKERS

Marx
class

Weber
institutions

Fanon
colonialism

Said
discourse

COURSE 1

Modern Middle East: State Formation & World Order

1. Ottoman / Qajar legacies and the nineteenth-century international order
2. World War I, mandates, borders and new states
3. Oil, strategic competition and external intervention
4. Postwar state-building and regional order

COURSE 2

Nationalism, Revolution & Political Change

1. Nationalism and national identity
2. Revolution: social, institutional and international explanations
3. Authoritarianism, opposition and social movements
4. Comparing revolutionary and reform trajectories

COURSE 3

Religion, Modernity & Society

1. Religion as institution, identity and political language
2. Secularization and its critics
3. Class, gender, generation, education and cultural change
4. Competing accounts of modernity in non-Western societies

COURSE 4

Country Analysis Lab: Iran / Iraq / Another Case

1. Build a historical timeline from primary + scholarly sources
2. Apply institutional, political-economy and sociological lenses
3. Apply colonial/postcolonial and international-relations lenses
4. Compare explanations: what does each illuminate, miss, or overstate?

ROADMAP SOURCES

University Links & Program Anchors

All URLs are printed in full, separated from the main course layout, and clickable in the PDF.

MAIN UNIVERSITY LINKS

Oxford Philosophy, Politics and Economics (PPE)
https://www.ppe.ox.ac.uk/

Oxford Academic / Oxford Research Encyclopedias
https://academic.oup.com/

Yale Open Courses - Introduction to Political Philosophy
https://oyc.yale.edu/political-science/plsc-114

Yale Open Courses - Foundations of Modern Social Theory
https://oyc.yale.edu/sociology/socy-151

Yale Open Courses - main site
https://oyc.yale.edu/

Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy
https://plato.stanford.edu/

PROGRAM RULE

4 courses per degree x 4 sessions = 16 sessions per degree. Each session uses one canonical text, university lecture, or high-quality scholarly essay as its anchor. Critical thinking is practiced inside every session: claim -> evidence -> assumptions -> competing explanation.

The next detailed pamphlet for each course can list exact chapters, audio links, listening time, key vocabulary, and discussion prompts.